

The Kakori incident is, like several others were, what Indian historian Sumit Sarkar calls, “Swadeshi dacoities”. The word “Swadeshi” in this case refers to the freedom movement that asked Indians to shun all foreign goods and buy only those made in India. The robbery’s aim was to raise funds by taking from Government property. The train had become a colonizer’s instrument, a symbol of oppression.

Robbery on the train

Seven members of the HRA, including Ramprasad Bismil, Chandrashekhar Azad, and Manmath Nath Gupta, had boarded a third-class carriage in the earmarked train. Three others, including Ashfaqullah Khan, were in a second-class carriage. Their task was to pull the chain and stop the train. As dusk fell and Khan pulled the chain, the train came to a screeching halt near the Kakori station. Some of the men rushed to the engine while others overpowered the guard keeping watch over the iron safe, which contained the money. They pushed the safe onto the ground and used a hammer and chisel to break it open, but this did not work. Meanwhile, two men stood on either side of the train, instructing passengers to stay inside as they were only after Government property.

Occasionally, they fired in the air to scare the more stubborn travellers. Seeing his compatriots struggle to break the safe, Khan took charge and started hammering. “Except the clang of the hammer all was quiet. Our bullets were regularly flying to keep the passengers glued to their seat,” Gupta would write later in his autobiography. Khan stopped briefly, when the Punjab Mail whizzed by, and then continued hammering. In the melee, there was one casualty, an Indian passenger, Ahmed Ali, who came out of his compartment to check on his wife and was killed by a flying bullet. The safe broke and the men gathered the money – Rs 4,601, 15 annas, and 6 paise in all, according to the case filed later, before melting into the darkness.